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Introduction to admin panels 30m

An admin panel enables administrators of an application, website or IT system to manage its configurations, settings, content and features and carry out oversight functions critical to the business. It allows them to view the state of the platform and take any action in the performance of their duties.

Take, for example, iQualify, the learning management system you are currently using. iQualify has an admin panel that is used by your tutors, who are authorised administrators. Authorised administrators can manage the course content (that is, edit, delete or update content), control the settings and performance and view students' progress. A student, on the other hand, can only view the course content and participate in the activities and discussion forums; they do not have access to the admin panel.

The admin panel is the core of a web application because, without it, you wouldn't be able to create any content or manage your web application. The admin panel cannot be accessed by regular users of your web application; it is hidden away in the backend of your web application, where only the administrators or individuals with permission are able to use the admin panel.

Your experience with WordPress earlier in this course would have demonstrated the frontend content pages and the backend administration side – the part that let you create the content and manage themes, users and plugins for your WordPress web application.

Developing an admin panel is a unique software design challenge. Businesses often regard it as a secondary consideration because it's not meant for end-users.

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A good admin panel will empower the administrators to make business-critical actions. It is not merely about giving information to the administrator to be consumed but about giving the administrator the capability to manage and carry out critical functions for the web application.

Here are some of the most common capabilities of an admin panel when it comes to user management:

- approve (or reject) new users and manage their profiles
- process user activities or transactions (for example, applications, purchases, queries) if manual action is required from administrators
- take interventions when users aren't complying with the platform's policies (for example, suspending privileges, blocking accounts)
- engage and communicate with users (such as pushing out notifications and messages, promoting products and deals, sending out customer surveys, etc.).

Other features that are common for an admin panel are:

- management of products, forms and core processes that relate to the purpose of the web application (for example, if you have an e-commerce website, then your admin panel would be used to manage your products and customers' orders)
- content management (edit pages, update links and post articles)
- security and permissions.



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An admin dashboard is often mistaken for the admin panel. The admin dashboard is the frontend or user interface of the admin panel. The admin dashboard is the interface that provides the administrator with an overview of crucial information such as data and reports, while an admin panel allows the administrator to carry out actions to manage the content and performance of the application and make any required changes.

Let's look at a real-life analogy to help understand an admin dashboard. Take, for example, the dashboard on your car. This dashboard provides crucial information on your speed, how much petrol you have and your mileage, as well as warnings for low oil or water levels. Admin dashboards in web applications do the same thing. They provide an overview of crucial information for the administrator.

There are four general subtypes of dashboards that differ based on the needs and level of an organisation:

- **Strategic** – used by high-level management to monitor an organisation's long-term strategy against their performance
- **Operational** – typically used by junior-level management to provide a view of the day-to-day operations and short-term goals

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- **Analytical** – typically used to visually present a large amount of data which is used to identify trends and compare datasets and provide a clear analysis of generated data
- **Tactical** – used to handle more detailed information that is used to track trends and performance.

The benefits of an admin dashboard are:

- accountability
- better decision-making
- real-time data
- data is presented in a user-friendly way
- easy to use.

Navigate to play.grafana.org (a sandboxed dashboard) for a live example of a dashboard demonstrating some of the above dashboard characteristics that you can explore.



Thoughts on this page?

